

"We don't look for just the skills but for a cultural fit as well"

If you are looking to future-proof your career as a developer, open source technology is clearly the way to go. The world of Big Data analytics is waiting for you with open arms. Dunhumby, a retail analytics multinational firm, is here in India to tap the country's vast talent pool. **Diksha P Gupta** from *Open Source For You* spoke to **Yael Cosset**, chief information officer, Dunhumby, on what the company looks for while hiring in India. Excerpts:

Q Dunhumby hosted its first hackathon in India recently. Why was this organised?

The worst thing that can happen to any company like ours is to become complacent—to convince itself that it knows how to do something better than anybody else and never challenge its own thinking. These events are an opportunity for us and for the people involved. One objective is to give people the opportunity to face a real life challenge with real life data, while interacting with experts to think about how they would push themselves forward. The second point is that for us it is an opportunity to think about a different approach to a challenge that we give. Some of the challenges that we pose to the groups participating in hackathons are around data processing, data encryption, data modelling, and we have an answer to every single problem we have posed. But we would love to be challenged by some of the thinking that happens in such events. The results that the teams participating in hackathons produce are not as important as their approach to the problem. Organising hackathons has always resulted in some really innovative thinking. Though this one was our first in India, we have had several such hackathons in other parts of the world.

Q How is an Indian hackathon different from those happening in other geographies, and how is the talent you see in this country different from that available worldwide?

I will not say that it is better or worse, but it sure is different. The variety of people that participated in our hackathon and the mix of talent that we got was very interesting. About one-third of the participants were university graduates and the rest were professionals. However, in some markets, including the US, we see a lot more students turning up for such hackathons. In Europe, it is a bit more balanced, whereas in India, we are seeing a higher number of professionals participating. One thing that impresses me in India is that there is a common passion for data and big intellectual challenges. People are always excited to be challenged and to compete to demonstrate that they have a better edge. That is very refreshing to see, and that is why we want to keep engaging the talent here at such hackathons.

Q Big Data is an emerging concept. People talk about it, but are the companies really accepting Big Data analytics as a part of their businesses?

I am not sure of this with respect to the Indian market, but we



Yael Cosset, chief information officer, Dunhumby

would always want more and more companies to be making better use of Big Data. The part that is important for us is that there is fantastic talent here, along with technology access, and the cultural passion for big complex challenges is more in India than in many other geographies.

Coming to your question on whether the companies are accepting Big Data, I would say that a lot of firms are realising the opportunity and have started to make use of data. For instance, in the retail industry, some companies have started making good use of Big Data analytics, but the nature of the retail industry is such that it is a new opportunity—one that is slowly evolving and is becoming bigger for the businesses here in India.

Q Do you use open source technology at Dunhumby?

Yes, a lot! We use a lot of open source technology, but we do not make our products open source. In fact, the world of big data is being majorly driven by open source technologies. We hire open source professionals as well.